to another single piece or another two-piece assembly. The sanding, cleaning, spreading of adhesive, wetting and clamping of subsequent pieces is exactly the same. In the past, I have created stacks of eight pieces without difficulty. I use my method only for bonding together pieces that will never be used as structural components and I use caution with my speeds and feeds of assembled components. This common-sense approach is no different than one you should be using for assemblies of wood as well. Corian turns, drills and finishes marvellously. Being a plastic, it will cut well with sharp tools but you can also use a scraper. I find a scraper is the best tool for hollowing after drilling.

Where Corian really excels is the finishing process. You can use the standard abrasives but will be able to impart a mirror finish by sanding far beyond the normal. After 400 grit, move to MicroMesh and proceed to that endpoint of 12,000. You can also use various plastic polishes if you wish. Buffing beyond that will also further improve the sheen. Over the years, I've used Corian for pens, funnels, lidded boxes, small platters, stemware bases and more.

Being a filled plastic, Corian cuts extremely well with woodturning tools

Hollowing and dishing tend to work better with a scraper. The aspect ratio of the material will have an impact on your choice

Gluing up the various colours or pieces allows for unavailable sizes and shapes. A good seam can be created

Don't lose sight of jigs, fixtures, workmounting aids, bushings and more with your alternative materials

Conclusions

If you haven't ventured out of turning wood, you are missing much of the fun. View your wood lathe solely as something to hold and spin your material. With that done, you can present your tools to any material you can hold safely and your tools can cut. Don't be bound by wood as your material. Other than hardened steel, chances are your high-speed woodturning tools will cut nearly anything.

Another suggestion is not to be locked into the rut of believing all your turnings need to be a final product. You can use your lathe to create fittings, special adapters, shims, bushings, workholding aids and more. I've made chair caster parts for a very favourite office chair when replacement parts were no longer available. We have club members who turn frozen fruits and vegetables in addition to wood at demos for the public. Giving a member of the audience a nicely turned potato to go along with a wooden top certainly gets a laugh from the crowd.

The point of this column wasn't to give you all of the answers but really to get you asking the question 'why not'? Try something different. Do it safely but experiment and have some fun! ●

Turning tools and equipment are very versatile. Whether turnings, bushings, jigs, or workholding aids, explore the world beyond wood

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